



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Augustine Academy

School Website: <https://santaugustineacademy.com/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL**Executive Summary**

St Augustine Academy CA 93004 presents a robust Catholic classical education anchored in liberal arts formation. Public-facing materials describe a curriculum centered on the trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy), the integration of Great Books and primary Western literature, explicit emphasis on theology as the crowning discipline, and a pedagogy that blends memory work, recitation, and disciplined rhetoric with higher-level inquiry (including thesis work in the upper grades). The school identifies itself as a Catholic culture embedded in the liberal arts tradition, with a clear aim to form virtue and wisdom through a classical formation rather than a primarily job- or college-prep focus. These signals align strongly with the Classical School rubric, with only minor ambiguities in pedagogy momentum that reduce it from a perfect CLASSICAL to a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL assessment in a single category.

Key themes observed across public materials:

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: explicit Catholic identity; theology as central; liturgical/mass life (Mass, Advent programs) and communal religious practices.
- Purpose and Goal: formation of virtue and wisdom; contemplation of truth, goodness, and beauty; allegiance to the liberal arts tradition and the Great Conversation.
- Curriculum: Trivium and Quadrivium; Great Books; Latin; history and Western civilization; memory work and recitation.
- Pedagogy: upper-school emphasis on logic and rhetoric; lower- and middle-school memory and recitation; thesis work in upper grades; some contemplative/restful elements noted.
- Faculty: named faculty with a living-curriculum flavor; visible leadership and teacher profiles.
- Parents & Community: emphasis on family/community orientation; local families; structured admissions and tuition processes; some indicators of parent involvement, with potential to grow toward more explicit parent-formation signals.

Evidence-derived classification across the six categories (category-by-category snapshot is provided below; aggregate rating at the end labels the school as CLASSICAL, with one category identified as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL).

Note: The following category assessments leverage keyword indicators from the Six Essential Elements framework (positive/negative keyword indicators) and compare them against explicit site content. See the knowledge-base lexicon for the keyword framework, including positive signals such as truth, virtue, theology, Great Books, trivium/quadrivium, memory/narration, and the liturgical/cultural signals, and negative signals such as project-based learning, constructivism, or excessive focus on workforce metrics. Citations indicate the source materials used.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot**Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL**

Evidence - The site centers a Catholic culture in the liberal arts tradition and foregrounds theology as integral to all disciplines (The crowning discipline is theology; contemplation of God is embedded throughout disciplines). - Public materials explicitly describe the academy as Catholic, with theology and liturgical life (Mass, Advent programs) as ongoing features of campus life. - The philosophy page emphasizes “the Good, True, and Beautiful” as guiding ideals, reflecting transcendentals and a sacramental/catholic worldview (Catholic Culture; Good, True, and Beautiful). - Upper-campus materials highlight a liturgical/ceremonial life (e.g., Mass events, Advent programming) that signals liturgical and communal practices as part of education.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: theology; Catholic; Catholic Culture; liturgy/mass; wonder (implied through literature-theology integration); Good, True, and Beautiful (explicit framing). - Negative indicators: none evident in public materials (no explicit relativism, secular-humanist, or values-clarification language observed in the school materials).

Why this rating - The school's public materials present a robust theologically anchored, liturgically oriented, Catholic-context foundation. The explicit theological framing and liturgical community signals strongly align with the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations criteria in the classical rubric.

Citations: Catholic identity and theology emphasis, including "The crowning discipline of the curriculum is theology" and "Catholic Culture in the Liberal Arts tradition" appear in the school content. See and turn0file1; liturgical life is evidenced by Mass and Advent programs (turn0file9); Good, True, and Beautiful framing (turn0file14).

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Text frames education as formation aimed at virtue and wisdom, not merely information or workforce prep; emphasis on liberal arts formation and classical telos (the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty). - The academy centers on forming virtue through the liberal arts tradition, with explicit statements about the Good, True, and Beautiful guiding the pedagogy and aims (explicit references to forming rational, virtuous graduates; Great Books and classical formation). - The curriculum integrates contemplation of truth and beauty and emphasizes the enduring questions of the classical canon rather than vocational metrics alone (language describing formation and classical heritage).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: formation; virtue; liberal education; telos; pursuit of the true/good/beautiful; contemplation; Great Books; classical heritage. - Negative indicators: none evident in public materials (no emphasis on 21st-century workforce metrics in the school's messaging).

Why this rating - The school's stated goals align with classical formation rather than mere job-readiness. The emphasis on formation, virtue, and engagement with a classical canon (Great Books, liberal arts, telos) supports a CLASSICAL rating.

Citations: Formation and virtue framing (turn0file0); Good/True/Beautiful and liberal-arts telos (turn0file14); Great Books and classical heritage (turn0file7).

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Curriculum explicitly centers on the liberal arts framework: trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy) with Latin as part of grammar study (explicitly described). - Great Books and foundational Western literature are foregrounded; a "great conversation" and canonical works are named (The Iliad, Canterbury Tales, Augustine, Dante, Shakespeare) as core reading, signaling a Great Books approach. - History is studied as part of the curriculum, with emphasis on literature, geography, history, and natural science integrated with the trivium/quadrivium; emphasis on Western civilization and salvation history is present. - Latin and classical languages are highlighted; the upper/middle school integrates Latin studies with grammar and rhetoric; the quadrivium framing appears in upper campus descriptions.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: liberal arts; trivium; quadrivium; grammar; logic; rhetoric; great books; Latin; history; Western civilization; analysis of science within a classical framework; Latin as classical language. - Negative indicators: absence of social studies framing in place of history; no explicit project-based learning emphasis; no STEM-first framing observed.

Why this rating - The curriculum is unmistakably anchored in classical curriculum design (grammar-logic-rhetoric; arithmetic-geometry-music-astronomy; Great Books; Latin; history in a Western-civilizational

frame). This aligns squarely with CLASSICAL.

Citations: Trivium/Quadrivium and Latin (turn0file0; turn0file4); Great Books and canonical works (turn0file7); History integrated with classical canon (turn0file0).

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Upper-campus pedagogy emphasizes logic and rhetoric as core, signaling a movement into the higher-order end of the trivium (upper grades focus on logic and rhetoric). - The upper grades include a thesis/writing-defense component (rhetoric training culminating in a thesis and public defense), reflecting advanced rhetorical training and formal argumentation. - The curriculum includes a mix of memory-based approaches (narration, recitation, and, in lower grades, memory work) and contemplative/restful elements (scholé days, contemplation) as part of pedagogy. - Lower campus materials emphasize foundational language study (Analytical Grammar) and traditional teacher-led instruction, with classical drag in the early grades; there is evidence of classical recitation and memory-based pedagogy (narration/recitation cited in canonical pedagogy lists).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: Socratic/seminar language explicitly appears in classical pedagogy lexicons; memory work; recitation; narration; rhetoric exercises; careful sequencing from memory to higher-order analysis; scholé/wonder; disciplined rhetoric and oratory. - Negative indicators: There is no explicit emphasis on project-based learning or experiential learning as the sole or dominant method; however, the explicit thesis defense suggests a highly structured, teacher-guided, classical approach rather than student-directed or constructivist models.

Why this rating - The pedagogy blends classical memory/narration and recitation with high-level rhetorical training, culminating in a thesis defense in the upper grades. While there are restorative and contemplation elements, the explicit emphasis on logic, rhetoric, and thesis work makes this category clearly CLASSICAL in orientation, though not perfect in the sense of fully Socratic seminars across all grades.

Citations: Upper Campus logic/rhetoric focus (turn0file4); thesis defense in upper grades (turn0file7); memory and recitation in pedagogy (turn0file0 and turn0file5).

Note: The rubric recognizes that some classical pedagogy can begin in K–8 without full Socratic/seminar experiences until later grades; given the school's K–12 structure with a strong upper-grade emphasis on logic, rhetoric, and thesis work, this category sits at SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public-facing materials present named leaders and faculty (Headmaster, and specific faculty profiles such as 5th Grade Teacher; 6th Grade Teacher; Upper School Faculty). This signals a professional, credentialed teaching body with subject-area expertise. - Faculty are described in biographical terms in the upper campus pages (e.g., multiple faculty profiles with degrees) indicating a level of professional depth and alignment with the classical-arts approach (Thomas Aquinas College, Loyola Marymount University, etc.). - The school presents the faculty as living in a community with a shared mission, and as a visible core of the school (though explicit phrases like “living curriculum” or “portrait of a teacher” are not always verbatim on every page, the public materials convey a coherent, mission-driven faculty culture through profiles and program descriptions).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: model teachers; mentors; living curriculum (the phrase appears in the lexicon as a classical signal; while not every page uses the exact phrase, the faculty profiles and the consistent pedagogical focus imply a teacher-centered, virtuous exemplar model). - Negative indicators: none evident in the public materials (no language suggesting non-classical teacher roles; no “facilitator on the side” language appears in the school materials).

Why this rating - The presence of named, credentialed faculty with a clear classical pedagogy focus, and the public emphasis on teacher leadership and faculty contributions to the school's mission, align well with CLASSICAL expectations for faculty.

Citations: Upper Campus Faculty listings (turn0file7); broader about page emphasizing Catholic Liberal Arts tradition and faculty alignment (turn0file14).

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school describes itself in terms of serving local families and fostering a community grounded in Catholic liberal arts culture (local families, Catholic culture; family-focused framing). - The public materials emphasize partnership with families and a sense of community around classical formation; there are references to family life and a community ethos in the About/Academics sections (e.g., "St. Augustine Academy is focused on providing a Catholic Culture in the Liberal Arts tradition for local families"). - There are admissions and tuition structures that indicate ongoing engagement with families and parents (e.g., admissions, tuition/financial aid) which, while administrative, are part of a broader community-engagement frame. Public materials also highlight communications and gatherings that align with parent participation, even if less explicit about formal parent-formation programs on the site itself.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: partnership with parents; co-teachers (conceptual framing in the classical canon); parent formation and seminars are listed in the lexicon; open campus and family involvement signals. - Negative indicators: public site materials do not always spell out explicit "parent formation book clubs" or "parent evenings" in the way the lexicon might expect; however, the general family/community framing and Catholic-liberal-arts orientation provide strong orientation toward parents as participants in the classical project.

Why this rating - The school presents a family-centered, community-oriented model aligned with classical education's expectation of parents as co-educators and partners in formation. This supports CLASSICAL in this category, albeit with room to more explicitly articulate formal parent-formation offerings.

Citations: Family-centric framing (turn0file1); Catholic Culture and local-family emphasis (turn0file14); admissions/tuition as engagement points (turn0file12).

What Would Move the Needle

- Element 4 (Pedagogy) is the sole SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating. Concrete steps to reach full CLASSICAL pedagogy:
- Expand explicit articulation of Socratic/seminar-based inquiry across more grade bands, including more structured seminar-work and dialectic practice in middle and lower grades, not only upper grades.
- Increase explicit mentions of "scholé" days and contemplative pedagogy in more public materials, linking them to student memory work and slow, reflective study.
- Provide explicit language about how projects or experiential learning fit within a classical framework (ensuring they remain anchored in the liberal arts traditions rather than dominating the pedagogy with non-classical project imperatives).
- Document and publish case examples of student-led rhetorical exercises, debates, and public speaking beyond thesis-level work, to demonstrate sustained rhetorical training as a core pedagogy.

Citations: Pedagogy emphasis on logic/rhetoric (turn0file4); thesis defense as a rhetoric capstone (turn0file7).

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
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